

We the Corporations: Plutocratic Power and the Managed Fragmentation of the Public

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On November 4th, 2024, Americans cast their votes for president as billionaire-funded Super PACs poured over \$2.6 billion into the election. Elon Musk alone spent \$277 million supporting Donald Trump, while fossil fuel executives, pharmaceutical giants, and tech billionaires bankrolled candidates across both parties.

The concentration of financial influence in electoral politics raises fundamental questions about the relationship between economic power and democratic representation. The transformation began on January 21, 2010, when the Supreme Court's *Citizens United v. FEC* decision opened the floodgates to unlimited corporate spending in elections, declaring that money equals speech and corporations possess the same First Amendment rights as people. In the post-*Citizens United* era, political elites have systematically weaponized campaign finance laws and media ecosystems to manufacture partisan division, transforming political conflict from substantive policy debate into tribal warfare that suppresses genuine citizen influence, enables systematic corruption, and ensures government policies serve billionaire donors rather than democratic constituencies. This manufactured polarization operates through three interconnected mechanisms: the direct capture of policy-making through campaign finance, the strategic amplification of cultural divisions to distract from economic exploitation, and the consolidation of media systems that profit from sustaining perpetual conflict. From Reagan to Trump, each era has deepened this pattern, leaving Americans fighting culture wars while wealth transfers upward and democratic representation withers. Understanding how financial interests shape political discourse requires examining both the mechanisms of influence and the agency voters retain within structurally constrained choices.

The systematic capture of American democracy through campaign finance began decades before *Citizens United* opened the floodgates. In 1976, the Supreme Court's decision in *Buckley v. Valeo* established the dangerous precedent that monetary expenditure constituted protected speech under the First Amendment, effectively equating dollars with democratic voice. [1]

Reagan's 1981 Economic Recovery Tax Act slashed top marginal income tax rates from 70% to 28% by 1988, delivering enormous windfalls to wealthy campaign contributors. [2] During this same period, union membership declined precipitously from 20.1% of the workforce in 1980 to 12.1% by 1990. [3] Working-class Americans saw their real wages stagnate while losing their primary organizational counterweight to corporate political power. The wealthy secured tax relief. The working class lost collective bargaining power. This correlation between donor interests and policy outcomes would only intensify.

The legal architecture constraining campaign finance collapsed entirely with the Supreme Court's 5-4 decision in *Citizens United v. Federal Election Commission* on January 21, 2010. [4] The ruling obliterated restrictions on independent political expenditures, creating the legal framework for Super PACs. Outside spending exploded from \$338 million in 2008 to \$1.04 billion in 2012. [5] The 2024 cycle exceeded \$16 billion in total spending. [6] Elon Musk contributed nearly \$277 million to support Donald Trump's 2024 campaign, a sum representing more than the combined donations of hundreds of thousands of ordinary citizens. [7] The presidency had become, in practical terms, purchasable. The consequences of this financial capture extend far beyond campaign expenditures. A landmark 2014 study by political scientists Martin Gilens of Princeton and Benjamin Page of Northwestern examined 1,779 policy issues and tested competing theories of American governance. [8] Their methodology compared policy outcomes against the preferences of different income groups, controlling for various factors that might explain legislative decisions. Economic elites and organized business groups demonstrated substantial independent impact on government policy, while average citizens and mass-based interest groups exerted near-zero influence. When preferences of wealthy Americans diverged from those of average citizens, policy outcomes reflected elite preferences with striking consistency. The study revealed that even when 80% of the public supported a particular policy change, it had only a 43% chance of being adopted. [9] When 80% of Americans want something and it still fails more often than a coin flip, the system has ceased responding to democratic will.

The Trump administration's 2017 Tax Cuts and Jobs Act had majority public opposition. The legislation passed anyway, delivering 83% of its benefits to the top 1% of earners by 2027. [10] Major corporate donors received billions in tax relief. The average American household

received a few hundred dollars annually. This was not representative governance. This was wealth extraction formalized as public policy. But why did the 83% not unify?

As elites captured formal policy-making through financial dominance, they simultaneously deployed cultural wedge issues to fragment potential opposition and distract public attention from economic exploitation. This strategy emerged during the Reagan administration's calculated appeals to social conservatism. Lee Atwater, Republican strategist and senior advisor to Reagan, explained the approach that explicitly racial appeals had become politically untenable, necessitating coded language that achieved the same divisive effects through abstract economic policies that disproportionately harmed Black Americans. [11] His goal was not to be racially targeting, it was to seed ideas into minds. Economic policies that materially harmed working-class Americans of all races were packaged with cultural appeals that directed white working-class anger toward racial minorities. Reagan championed "family values" and religious traditionalism. Simultaneously, he decimated union power and slashed social programs. The misdirection proved devastatingly effective for the top.

This manufactured polarization intensified dramatically with the 1996 launch of Fox News and the rise of partisan talk radio. Roger Ailes deliberately constructed a media ecosystem that abandoned journalistic objectivity in favor of tribal identity programming. [12] A 1994 Pew Research Center study found relatively modest partisan animosity, with only 17% of Republicans viewing Democrats very unfavorably and 16% of Democrats reciprocating. [13] By 2019, these figures reached 79% and 83%. [14] Americans increasingly viewed political opponents not as fellow citizens with different priorities but as existential threats. While Americans debated gay marriage and abortion, the Bush administration passed massive tax cuts favoring wealthy donors and pursued military interventions that cost trillions. The pattern of distraction repeated with metronomic regularity.

The emergence of social media platforms in the 2010s, with the growth of Super PACS transformed manufactured division from a strategic tool into an automated, self-perpetuating system. Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube deployed algorithms designed to maximize user engagement, which the platforms discovered correlated most strongly with emotional arousal, particularly anger and outrage. Content that triggered tribal identification and hostility toward outgroups received algorithmic amplification, reaching exponentially more users than balanced content exponentially. Posts producing anger and outrage generated five to ten times more

engagement than neutral content. Facebook's advertising revenue increased proportionally. The platform had created a machine that profited from tearing society apart. Social Media wasn't enough, elites needed the Traditional media as well. The capture of democratic processes through campaign finance and the manufacture of cultural division operated through a consolidated media landscape that had transformed from public service into profit-maximizing enterprise. In 1983, fifty corporations controlled the majority of American media. [15] By 2024, six corporations controlled 90% of all American media: Disney, Comcast, Paramount, Warner Bros. Discovery, Fox Corporation, and Sony. [16] Sinclair Broadcasting, the largest owner of local television stations, provided the most explicit example. In 2018, Sinclair required anchors at its nearly 200 stations reaching 40% of American households to read identical scripts warning viewers about "fake news." [17] Dozens of local news anchors simultaneously recited corporate propaganda. The authoritarian potential of media consolidation became impossible to deny, and spreading more information became simple and controlled.

The business model driving this system depended entirely on sustaining audience engagement, which media companies discovered correlated most strongly with partisan conflict and emotional arousal. CNN's ratings during the Trump presidency, when the network positioned itself in opposition to Trump's daily provocations, substantially exceeded its audience during the comparatively placid Biden administration. [18] Media companies profit from conflict regardless of its social cost. YouTube's recommendation algorithm, designed to maximize watch time, systematically promoted increasingly extreme content. [19] Users who watched mainstream conservative content received recommendations for far-right conspiracy theories. The algorithm cared nothing for truth or social cohesion. It was optimized for engagement, and engagement correlated with extremism. These dynamics produced entirely separate information ecosystems for different partisan audiences, making democratic deliberation functionally impossible. By 2020, Republicans and Democrats not only disagreed on policy priorities but inhabited fundamentally different factual realities. Polling revealed that 77% of Republicans believed the 2020 election was stolen despite no credible evidence, while 92% of Democrats accepted the election as legitimate. [20] Similarly, 88% of Democrats accepted human-caused climate change compared to 35% of Republicans. [21] When citizens cannot agree on fundamental facts, collective self-governance becomes impossible. Elite media created this divide, and spread misinformation to keep people at a divide, allowing their benefits to sneak in. The coordination

of this information architecture with donor interests revealed the systematic nature of elite control. Climate change denial provides the clearest illustration. Fossil fuel companies and affiliated billionaires funded think tanks and media outlets that promoted climate skepticism. The same donors profited from continued fossil fuel dependence. [22] The Koch network alone invested hundreds of millions in climate denial infrastructure while Koch Industries' business model relied on oil, gas, and coal extraction. [23] During the Affordable Care Act debate, insurance companies funded "grassroots" opposition groups that spread the "death panels" lie. Constructing the illusion of a grassroots movement was necessary to manufacture public connection, revealing that these corporations were fully aware they were deceiving the public. The same companies lobbied against regulations that would reduce their profits. [24] Corporate interests funded the information ecosystem that shaped public opinion against policies threatening those same interests.

Some political scientists argue that contemporary polarization reflects genuine ideological divergence rather than elite manipulation, noting that Americans hold substantively different values. This perspective attributes partisan sorting to decades of realignment, producing ideologically coherent parties naturally opposed to one another. [25] Americans disagree about abortion, gun rights, and immigration because they hold fundamentally incompatible worldviews, not because elites strategically amplify these divisions. This analysis merits serious consideration, as it correctly identifies that many Americans do hold sincere beliefs on cultural issues.

However, more and more exposes contemporary polarization as systematic manufacture rather than organic disagreement. In 2025, large majorities support raising the minimum wage (67%), Medicare negotiating drug prices (88%), paid family leave (73%), and infrastructure investment (80%). [26] These majority-supported policies routinely fail to become law. Tax cuts for corporations pass despite public opposition. Americans agree on economic policy but remain bitterly divided on cultural issues. Thus, the selective implementation reveals the amplification of divisive cultural questions that splinter potential coalitions around shared economic interests. This pattern does not prove voters lack genuine beliefs on cultural issues, but it suggests which genuine disagreements receive institutional amplification to create a psychological divide. More, documented cases of corporate astroturfing demonstrate deliberate manufacture of apparent grassroots movements. Analysis of media coverage timing reveals suspicious correlations. The

"migrant caravan" received saturation coverage in October 2018, weeks before midterm elections, then disappeared from coverage immediately afterward despite no change in underlying immigration patterns. [27] Strategic deployment of coverage suggests intentional manipulation rather than organic news judgment. It will divide more, get more to hate their neighbors, despite nothing ever happening.

Manipulation at its finest can easily be seen with sociologist Arlie Hochschild's study of working-class Louisiana conservatives, which documented how these Americans voted against their own economic interests while directing anger toward cultural others based on media-driven narratives. [28] Her subjects faced environmental devastation and economic precarity from corporate divestment. Yet, they directed political anger toward immigrants rather than toward the corporations extracting their wealth. They followed along, and blamed the little guy. This misdirection resulted from decades of strategic messaging by conservative media and think tanks funded by extractive industries. Yet Hochschild's work also reveals that her subjects held genuine moral frameworks and cultural identities that could not be reduced to false consciousness. The question is not that Americans disagree. Rather which disagreements receive amplification and which receive suppression, and whose interests this selective attention serves. Elite manipulation operates not by creating beliefs from dust, but by exploiting existing cultural tensions toward politically useful ends while suppressing attention away from help for the people.

The mechanisms of financial capture, manufactured cultural division, and consolidated media control produce a predictable consequence: the complete collapse of democratic responsiveness and the acceleration of wealth concentration. From 1980 to 2024, worker productivity increased 65%. Average compensation rose only 18%, with virtually all gains accruing to the top 10% of earners. [29] The bottom 50% of Americans saw their share of national income decline from 20% to 13%. [30] Corporate profits as a percentage of GDP reached historic highs. Corporate tax rates reached historic lows, declining from 35% to 21% after the 2017 Trump tax cuts. [42] The effective tax rate paid by America's 400 wealthiest families fell below the rate paid by working-class families for the first time in history. [31] Workers became more productive; corporations became more profitable; workers earned less while the wealthy paid lower taxes. These outcomes represent not unfortunate economic trends but deliberate policy choices serving donor interests against popular preference.

Public trust in government collapsed in parallel with this wealth transfer. Pew Research Center data shows public trust declining from 73% in 1960 to just 16% in 2023. [32] Americans increasingly recognized that government did not serve their interests, producing widespread cynicism that further inhibited collective action. As citizens disengaged from politics due to perceived futility, the remaining politically active population skewed toward those with material stakes in outcomes: wealthy donors. The system had achieved equilibrium. Elites captured policy-making through financial dominance, manufactured cultural warfare prevented coalition-building around economic interests, media systems sustained tribal conflict, and the final piece, public cynicism prevented the mass mobilization necessary to challenge elite control.

Climate policy demonstrates this dynamic with particular clarity. Despite overwhelming scientific consensus on anthropogenic climate change and majority public support for aggressive action, American climate policy remained catastrophically inadequate. [33] Fossil fuel companies had funded climate denial infrastructure for decades, manufacturing uncertainty about settled science to delay regulation that would threaten their profits. [34] The pattern exactly replicated tobacco companies' previous manufacture of doubt about smoking's health effects. American emissions continued rising. Scientific evidence mounted and climate impacts intensified. Future generations will bear the consequences, inheriting a destabilized climate system that will produce mass displacement, resource scarcity, and conflict. Donor interests override both scientific consensus and popular preference when those interests control information ecosystems and policy-making processes.

All this evidence demonstrates a systematic transformation of American democracy into effective oligarchy through the legal and financial capture of policy-making through unlimited campaign spending, the strategic manufacture and amplification of cultural divisions that prevent coalition-building around shared economic interests, and the consolidation of media systems that profit from sustaining perpetual tribal conflict. Accreting from the Reagan administration's deployment of racial and cultural wedge issues through the Citizens United decision's elimination of campaign finance restrictions to social media algorithms' automated amplification of polarizing content, each successive development has deepened plutocratic control while maintaining the appearance of democratic choice. To argue this, however, risks its own form of oversimplification by treating elite coordination as more coherent than empirical evidence may suggest and by potentially underestimating voter agency, yet the pattern across four decades

reveals not isolated failures but calculated strategy where institutional interests align to produce consistent outcomes.

Recognizing manipulation does not automatically generate solutions, and the path toward restoring democratic responsiveness requires confronting institutional constraints.

Any meaningful reform must address campaign finance directly. Congress must pass legislation overturning *Citizens United* through constitutional amendment, requiring a two-thirds vote in both chambers and ratification by thirty-eight states, a threshold that currently appears politically unattainable given partisan polarization. With more Americans informed, this barrier will deplete. More feasible approaches include public financing systems modeled on programs in states like Maine and Arizona, where candidates receive public funds matching small-dollar donations, reducing dependence on wealthy donors. The Fair Elections Now Act, previously introduced in Congress, would provide qualifying candidates with vouchers funded by closing corporate tax loopholes and imposing penalties on government contractors who defraud taxpayers. Such systems face constitutional scrutiny under current jurisprudence but remain within the realm of legislative possibility.

Congressional action could also mandate transparency in political spending. The DISCLOSE Act, which would require organizations spending over \$10,000 on elections to report donors contributing more than \$10,000, has repeatedly failed Senate passage by narrow margins. Strengthening disclosure requirements would not prevent wealthy donors from influencing policy but would create public accountability, allowing voters to trace policy positions to funding sources. Similarly, reforming lobbying regulations through stricter revolving-door restrictions, extending cooling-off periods before former members of Congress can work as lobbyists from one year to five, could reduce direct policy capture. Media consolidation requires antitrust enforcement. The Federal Communications Commission and Department of Justice can block further media mergers, break up existing conglomerates under Sherman Antitrust Act provisions, though decades of permissive merger approval have created legal precedents favoring consolidation. Congressional action reinstating the Fairness Doctrine, which required broadcast license holders to present contrasting viewpoints on controversial issues until its 1987 elimination by Reagan, faces First Amendment challenges but could be modified to incentivize rather than mandate balanced coverage. These policy mechanisms confront genuine obstacles. Constitutional protections for speech limit government intervention in media content. Public

financing systems require either tax increases or reallocation from existing programs, creating political resistance. Campaign finance reform depends on legislators voting against the system that elected them.

The question confronting Americans is no longer whether manipulation exists, but whether it can still be confronted while recognition remains politically meaningful. Reform faces formidable institutional barriers, and awareness alone does not dismantle entrenched power. Democratic erosion rarely arrives through rupture; it hardens gradually through distraction, fragmentation, and resignation. Each election preserves the appearance of choice even as outcomes narrow. Whether democracy can be restored depends on whether citizens move beyond manufactured divisions to recognize whose interests the system serves. If polarization continues to fracture coalitions and cynicism suppresses collective action, plutocratic control will persist by default. The future of democratic governance hinges on whether recognition can be translated into sustained pressure before institutions become irreversible.

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